

Necessitism and contingentism

PHIL UA-78 Metaphysics

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9th September 2026

Necessitism (reminder)

Necessitism Necessarily, everything is, necessarily, identical to something.

$$\Box \forall x \Box \exists y (x = y)$$

NB: we mean *metaphysical* necessity and *unrestricted* quantification.

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For contingentism, Williamson himself does a good job of channeling the sensibility:

- » Is it also contingent what things there are? 'Yes' seems the obvious answer. The universe could have evolved differently, so that there was never any money, or even any non-pecuniary physical object shaped like this coin. In those circumstances, not only would this coin not have been a coin, it would not have been anything at all; it simply would not have been. Thus there is actually something that could have been nothing. (MLM, p. 1)

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For necessitism, we could consider the following Simple Argument that some arbitrarily chosen object a is necessarily identical to something.

P1 It is necessary that a is identical to itself.

P2 It is necessary that if a is identical to itself, it is identical to something.

C So, it is necessary that a is identical to something.

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Some contingentists reject P1. Others reject P2.

Existence

What is it for an object to *exist*? Many philosophers have endorsed the following account:

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That sounds obviously wrong! Many things that now exist haven't existed forever; most of those things could have never existed.

So, any case for necessitism cuts against the Logical Analysis.

What's an alternative to the Logical Analysis? We could consider for example:

The Spatial Analysis of Existence For an object to exist is for it to be located in space.

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A worry about this view: 'God exists' does not seem to imply 'God is located in space'.

Williamson on existence

Williamson suggests that 'exists' is context-sensitive, and can express a range of different properties.

He thinks that the Logical Analysis is wrong for many ordinary uses of 'exist', but right for some uses made by philosophers. To avoid the danger of equivocation, he never uses 'exist' himself.

His go-to word for the property a person would have lacked if they had never been conceived is 'concrete'. This is supposed to be a bit flexible way—you could equate it with 'spatially located', but I guess he'd also want to apply it to gods, souls, etc. (if there were such things).

- Note: some philosophers treat 'abstract' as meaning 'not concrete', but Williamson doesn't.

One more note on ‘exists’

Often, an English sentence with a bare plural subject, of the form ‘[noun]s [verb]’, means something along the lines of ‘all [noun]s [verb]’, or ‘typical [noun]s [verb]’—a so called ‘generic’ reading.

‘[noun]s exist’ is not like that! ‘Unicorns exist’ doesn’t mean anything like ‘All unicorns exist’ or ‘Typical unicorns exist’—it is closer to ‘Something is a unicorn’ or ‘There are unicorns’.

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This isn’t something so special about ‘exists’: there are other verb phrases that also suggest so-called ‘existential’ readings. ‘Spotted lanternflies are in New York City’ means ‘Some spotted lanternflies are in New York City’.

Concreteness

Many contingentists accept something like the following thesis:

Concreteness Essentialism Every concrete object is such that necessarily, if it is something, it is concrete.

Given necessitism, this would imply that every concrete object is necessarily concrete. Since this seems obviously false, necessitists must reject Concreteness Essentialism.

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They'll also likely reject many other claims with the same structure, e.g.:

Person Essentialism Every person is such that necessarily, if it is identical to something, it is a person.

Concreteness Essentialism is naturally coupled with the following claim:

Non-concreteness Essentialism Every object that is not concrete is necessarily not concrete.

(Given the B axiom, each of these follows from the necessary truth of the other.)

Williamson rejects Non-concreteness Essentialism. He thinks there are *lots* of contingently non-concrete things.

How plausible is Non-Concreteness Essentialism?

- » We are going to die, and that makes us the lucky ones. Most people are never going to die because they are never going to be born. The potential people who could have been here in my place but who will in fact never see the light of day outnumber the sand grains of Arabia. Certainly those unborn ghosts include greater poets than Keats, scientists greater than Newton. We know this because the set of possible people allowed by our DNA so massively exceeds the set of actual people. In the teeth of these stupefying odds it is you and I, in our ordinariness, that are here. (Richard Dawkins, *Unweaving the Rainbow*.)

An argument against Non-Concreteness Essentialism

Supposed we have a collection of 10 blades and 10 handles.

If we had attached any blade to any handle, we would have made a knife, and that knife would have been such that if we hadn't attached that blade to that handle, it would not have been concrete.

This seems to imply that there are at least 100 possible knives that we could make out of these blades and handles. But at most 10 of these are concrete; so we can conclude that there are contingently non-concrete objects.

- NB we do not have to say that any of the non-concrete possible knives are *knives*. Just as a ticket can be a possible winner without being a winner, an object can (according to Williamson) be a possible knife without being a knife.

How does that argument relate to necessitism?

Although I suppose most contingentists are Non-Concreteness Essentialists, there is no logical contradiction in being a contingentist while still agreeing that there are millions of non-concrete possible knives that could be made out of our blades and handles.

Such a contingentist should think twice before accepting the standard view that I would have been nothing if my parents had never met—maybe I would just have been non-concrete, like an unmade possible knife.

Q: could any of these possible knives have been nothing? If so, under what circumstances?

Plausibly, the non-being of blade B and handle H would suffice for the non-being of the possible knife that would be made from them. But what would secure the non-being of B and H?

A Democritean might think that getting rid of anything requires getting rid of some atom.

Many Non-concreteness Essentialists have responded to arguments like the one about the knives by saying that although speeches like 'There are 100 possible knives that could be made from these blades and handles' are not *literally true*, they are still acceptable as a kind of *loose talk*.

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The techniques involved are quite tricky, and tend to produce sentences much too complicated for it to be plausible that those producing the original sentences in any sense 'had them in mind'.

The 'grounding argument' for Non-concreteness Essentialism

Explaining modal differences

In many salient respects, non-concrete objects (if there are any) are all alike. They are alike with respect to shape (they don't have any), location (they don't have one), mass (they don't have one). . . .

But opponents of Non-concreteness Essentialism (including necessitists) think that there are all sorts of *modal* differences between non-concrete objects. For example, it's plausible that a non-concrete object that could be a knife couldn't be a person, and one that could be a person couldn't be a knife.

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This gives rise to a challenge: what *explains* these modal differences?

- » The challenger may argue that an object needs non-modal properties to ground its modal properties. For instance, a lump of clay is malleable (a modal property) because it has a certain microphysical structure (a non-modal property). (MLM p. 13)

Explaining modal differences

The basic shape of the argument:

P1 Any two objects that have all the same qualitative *C*-properties have all the same qualitative modal properties.

P2 Any two non-concrete objects have all the same qualitative *C*-properties.

P3 If there are contingently non-concrete objects, they do not all have the same qualitative modal properties.

C So, there are no contingently non-concrete objects.

P1 is in turn motivated by some thought about explanation. It's far from clear that this is a good motivation—the task of “explaining” *any* facts about metaphysical possibility and necessity is quite difficult if we are not allowed to appeal to any other facts about metaphysical possibility and necessity!

Explaining modal differences

We can give an independent argument against P1:

Consider a table and the hunk of wood that composes it. They have all the same C-properties, but have different modal properties—the hunk could have been shaped nothing like a table, but the table couldn't; the table could have been bigger but the hunk couldn't.... (A famous similar case: a clay statue and the lump of clay that composes it)

- ▶ If we include *temporal* properties like 'having once been smaller' among the C-properties, we may need to change the example to one involving *permanent* coincidence.
- ▶ E.g.: We form a lump of bronze and a bronze statue simultaneously (by pouring molten copper and tin into a mould) and destroy them simultaneously (by dissolving in acid). Still, they seem to have different modal properties!

The Converse Barcan Formula

Ruth Barcan Marcus (1946) proposed the following two principles:

Barcan Formula If each thing is necessarily F , then it's necessary that everything is F .

Converse Barcan Formula If it's necessary that everything is F , then each thing is necessarily F .

(Feel free to understand these as prefixed by 'For every property $F \dots$ '—although be warned that our usual approach to 'property' talk is controversial in this particular debate.)

CBF is the one we care about. (Each follows from the necessity of the other given the B axiom.)

An uncontroversial claim: *It is necessary that everything is identical to something.*

- ▶ Even contingentists believe this. Of course they don't think that it's necessary that, e.g., *Marcus* is identical to something. But they think it's possible that Marcus isn't identical to something despite everything being identical to something—the non-being of Marcus would mean that everything could be a certain way without Marcus being that way.

We can plug this in to CBF to get that *each thing is necessarily identical to something.*

- ▶ We just need to slap an initial 'necessarily' onto this to get the official version of necessitism, which we can do assuming CBF holds of necessity.

From necessitism to CBF

In fact, given logical principles that are accepted by both necessitists and contingentists, necessitism is *equivalent* to CBF.

1. Suppose that it's necessary that everything is F , and let a be some object.
2. By necessitism, it's necessary that (everything is F and something is identical to a).
3. But for any F and G , 'Everything is F and something is G ' implies 'Something is both F and G '.
4. So, it's necessary that something is both F and identical to a .
5. But by Leibniz's Law, it's necessary that if a is identical to something F , a is F .
6. So, it's necessary that a is F .

Why believe CBF?

The attraction of CBF may be clearer if we state it as follows, using ' p entails q ' to mean 'it's (metaphysically) necessary that if p obtains then q obtains'.

CBF (restated) For each object a , the state of affairs *everything is F* entails the state of affairs *a is F* .

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Obviously this has no plausibility for typical restricted interpretations of 'everything' like 'everything in my fridge'.

But it's hard to resist when it's specified that 'everything' is to be interpreted as unrestricted—the failure of $Q(F)$ to entail $F(a)$ looks like a great sign that Q is *not* absolutely unrestricted!

Why believe CBF?

To turn that into a bit more of an argument: suppose that a is something that could have been nothing. For a given property F , define ' $\text{Everything}+ \text{ is } F$ ' to mean ' $\text{Everything is } F$, and $a \text{ is } F$ '.

Everything+ is F entails *everything is F*; but (according to the contingentist), *everything is F* does not entail *everything+ is F*.

If we called *everything+* a quantifier, we would have to say that *everything* is a restriction of it, contravening the stipulation that *everything* is an absolutely unrestricted quantifier.

But *everything+* seems to behave, logically, like a universal quantifier.